

Berkeley Neighbors for Housing & Climate Action 2026 Candidate Questionnaire

Candidate Name: Ross Bernet

District / Office being sought: Berkeley City Council District 1

1. Berkeley's Housing Element lays out the city's plan for new housing construction through 2031, ensuring the city can meet its Regional Housing Needs Allocation (RHNA) of ~9,000 homes across a range of income levels.

The Housing Element commits Berkeley to a number of major policy changes in order to meet state requirements for affirmatively furthering fair housing, including a San Pablo Specific Plan and upzoning along North Shattuck, Solano, and College Ave, among other items.

What is your view on the Housing Element and these policies? What are the most important things we need to do to implement the City's Housing Element?

Please discuss your ideas and priorities around:

- a. San Pablo specific plan
- b. Zoning for housing in high-resource commercial areas like North Shattuck, Solano, and College Ave
- c. Extending 'middle housing' zoning to some parts of the Hills, while balancing fire risk
- d. Other strategies for Berkeley to affirmatively further fair housing

Housing affordability is a regional problem that no single city can solve alone, which is why I support state level tools like the Housing Element requirement, which ensures Berkeley plans for adequate zoned capacity to meet its RHNA targets. I also support the equity requirements built into that plan around affirmatively furthering fair housing. As councilmember, I'd want to make sure the zoning changes required by the Housing Element are implemented in a way that distributes new housing across the city, rather than concentrating it in lower resource neighborhoods.

I'd prioritize progress on the four commercial corridors: San Pablo, North Shattuck, Solano, and College. These represent the largest opportunities for added zoned capacity. I think it's important to approach San Pablo and the other corridors on a similar timeline and with similar ambition, even though the streets differ in their constraints and San Pablo runs through a less affluent area than the other three. Moving forward on all four together, rather than sequencing one before the others, would help ensure the benefits and impacts are shared fairly across the city.

The corridors are where I'd focus first, since they offer the greatest potential for new housing, including in higher resource areas. That said, Middle Housing also plays an important role. It brings housing options to more neighborhoods citywide and can create more ownership opportunities, particularly while condo defect liability reform (needed to bring back ownership

oriented multi unit development) remains unresolved. I'd support extending Middle Housing zoning further into the city, including reexamining the Hillside Overlay boundary, which excluded some areas from the Middle Housing Ordinance. Since that boundary was drawn before more current fire risk modeling was available, I think it's worth revisiting those boundaries using updated fire data so our policies are consistent with the reasoning behind them.

2. Berkeley's Climate Action Plan sets forth a goal of 80% reduction in greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions by 2050. Today, the two major sources of GHG emissions in Berkeley are from gas-powered automobiles and natural gas used in buildings.

Berkeley has a variety of plans and programs intended to help address these emissions, including the Electric Mobility Roadmap and the Berkeley Existing Building Electrification Strategy. Other related efforts include the Bicycle Plan and Pedestrian Master Plan, as well as the City's now-defunct natural gas ban on new buildings.

What is your view on the Climate Action Plan and these strategies? What are the most important things we need to do to address greenhouse gas emissions?

I strongly support the Climate Action Plan's goals, but Berkeley has been better at setting ambitious targets than at funding, enforcing, and executing on them. The switch to renewable electricity via Ava Community Energy has enabled us to make significant progress towards reducing GHGs from building electrical consumption, but a reduction in GHGs from transportation remains a significant challenge. We would also be in much better shape regarding building gas consumption had the 2019 gas ban not been overturned in 2023.

Given that transportation-related GHGs represent roughly 60% of Berkeley's emissions, we need to pursue strategies that more aggressively incentivize alternatives to private gas-powered automobile use. The city's population has consistently voted in favor of reducing our climate footprint and setting ambitious targets, but car-dependency remains entrenched in Berkeley, and when push comes to shove, residents are extremely reluctant to give up parking spaces and other conveniences of automobiles.

There are a few things I'd like to see:

- 1. Accountability and enforcement of reaching our Climate Action Plan targets. This could include mechanisms such as automatic triggers to divert more financial resources to climate-smart strategies if we are not on track to meeting our targets.*
- 2. Better tracking of our targets. I reviewed the recent 2025 update to our Climate Action Plan targets from the City Manager's office, and it was not immediately obvious to me how we're doing. We are making progress, but it remains unclear if we are on track. I want to see a chart that shows our status compared to our goal and a letter grade rating our progress.*
- 3. I am supportive of the 2026 BESO requirement for point-of-sale of homes that require upgrades to move homes towards electrification. I would like to see this become a*

funded requirement, rather than an unfunded mandate. The city should do some kind of incentive matching to offset the cost of the electrification upgrades. I'd also expand the Climate Equity Fund so income-qualified residents aren't left behind.

4. *I want to see fewer goals that are tracked clearly. I'd rather Berkeley hit fewer, better-resourced goals than continue adopting plans we lack the capacity to deliver on. And we need to treat clear reporting as a necessary component of our goals so we know how we're doing on them.*

3. In your opinion, what was the most important City Council vote on Berkeley's housing crisis in the past four years? Briefly describe the issue, what you think of the Council's decision, and what you would have done had you been on the Council. For incumbents, please describe why you voted the way you did, and what you think now about that vote.

The most important city council vote on Berkeley's housing crisis in the past four years was the vote to revise and adopt our Housing Element. It set us on the track to eliminate single-family zoning across most of the city. It articulated the need for a streamlined demolition ordinance. It committed us to a large-scale upzoning of the South Side, and last but not least, it committed us to upzoning San Pablo and the wealthier commercial corridors of North Shattuck, College, and Solano. We would not be on the path to providing thousands of units worth of zoned capacity across our city, and in some of our wealthiest neighborhoods, were it not for this Housing Element vote and Councilmember Kesarwani's commitment to truly affirmatively furthering fair housing. Were I on council at that time, I would have joined the majority in voting for Councilmember Kesarwani's supplemental.

4. In your opinion, what was the most important climate or environmental issue faced by the Berkeley City Council in the last four years? Briefly describe the issue, what you think of the Council's decision, and what you would have done had you been on the Council. For incumbents, please describe why you voted the way you did, and what you think now about that vote.

I believe that housing policy is climate policy, and so my answer here very closely tracks my answer above. Transportation is the leading source of greenhouse gas emissions in Berkeley, and the only way we will reduce our vehicle miles traveled is if we build more densely. I strongly support the use of biking, walking, and transit to get around, but the only way that that will be truly an option is if we build dense communities so that there's less distance to cover to get to your destination. Dense housing construction also reduces the pressure to build high fire risk housing in our open space, which should be protected and left wild. Multifamily housing is much less carbon intensive to build and operate than single-family housing because it uses fewer resources per resident and has much lower per unit energy requirements to heat and cool. What's more, Berkeley has one of the mildest climates in the country, making it an ideal place to live a low-carbon lifestyle. If we build more homes here in Berkeley, more people could live on less carbon.

To that end, my answer remains the same: Council's most important climate vote in the last four years was the vote on our Housing Element to plan for increased zoned capacity throughout the city, but in particular along the transit-rich corridors of San Pablo, North Shattuck, College, and Solano.

5. To achieve its RHNA goals, Berkeley must continue to build homes for all income levels. These new residents will need to travel within Berkeley. Greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions from transportation comprise roughly 60% of total emissions in Berkeley.

How would you ensure that Berkeley continues to reduce GHG emissions while adding new homes?

As mentioned above, building more densely in Berkeley is the best way to reduce our per capita greenhouse gas emissions within the city, within California, and even across the entire United States. Berkeley is one of the lowest carbon places in the country to live.

I would support a ban on natural gas infrastructure in new construction, presuming we can find a legally durable mechanism to do so, and I would try to find additional ways to incentivize energy-efficient all-electric construction.

I would also support incentives for the use of lower-carbon building materials such as mass timber. Mass timber construction has the potential to greatly reduce the embedded carbon in our buildings, but it's still too new to take advantage of economies of scale. The more buildings utilize this building material, the closer we get to the point where mass timber takes off.

And finally, we need to pair new housing construction with effective and safe biking, pedestrian, and micro-mobility infrastructure and service-oriented transit improvements that enable residents to effectively get around Berkeley without the need for a car.

6. Walking and biking presents opportunities to help Berkeley residents reduce their GHG emissions, but safety concerns can be a major deterrent.

What is your perspective on how we should address pedestrian and cyclist safety on our streets?

Housing affordability and cyclist safety were the reasons why I ran for the Sierra Club Northern Alameda County Executive Committee. I am fully committed to delivering safe streets for everyone and all modes of transportation in Berkeley. However, it is pedestrians and cyclists who are most at risk due to our current unsafe street design and I will work to ensure our infrastructure protects them. Berkeley already has a Complete Streets Policy and Bicycle and Pedestrian Plans; what's missing is council leadership committed to implementing them. We also have funding from Measure FF to support these plans. I would be the strongest advocate on council for making sure that our measure FF funding prioritizes street safety improvements, and not just repaving. I want to ensure that our decisions on street safety improvements don't

get tied up in years of delay, commission hearings, and extra votes, so I would advocate for streamlined implementation of our street safety plans. I'd like to develop policy that makes it easier, faster, and cheaper to build cycling infrastructure and helps us avoid the trials of the current status quo, as painfully evidenced by the multiyear Hopkins Bike Lane Saga.

7. Berkeley has a long history of using zoning, restrictive covenants and redlining to achieve racial and economic segregation. This history continues to shape Berkeley today.

Recent research by the Turner Center at UC Berkeley suggests that inclusionary zoning requirements, which mandate on-site restricted affordable housing in new developments, may have the effect of reducing overall housing construction, including the production of affordable units. However, on-site affordable housing can also be an effective tool for desegregating neighborhoods.

What is your perspective on how Berkeley should use inclusionary zoning requirements, versus other affordable housing development options (such as in-lieu fees)?

First of all, I want to call out that inclusionary zoning is a misnomer. It is not a zoning policy, but rather a tax on new construction. Without mechanisms to cross subsidize affordable units, researchers at UC Irvine found that each BMR unit wound up creating an additional \$800,000 of costs borne by other renters (as opposed to homeowners), which is extremely regressive. I still believe in the importance of desegregating housing development, so I favor any way that we can encourage on-site subsidized affordable units while still allowing a housing project to keep per-unit costs down. To that end, I support density bonuses and even a local density bonus program that might go above and beyond state density bonus law. I also would support exploring a mechanism for funded inclusionary units in market-rate housing projects.

Funding for off-site affordable housing development can help provide some of the most deeply affordable units and units with additional services such as permanent supportive housing, which are essential tools in a just and compassionate housing system. We need an all of the above approach. However, taxing housing in order to get more housing is a way to get less housing overall and keep housing costs high. We should prioritize other streams of funding for 100% affordable housing projects, such as another local bond measure to replace the Measure O funding, which has run out. I'm also very hopeful about the regional affordable housing bond measure, which could go a long way to solving the struggle to fund affordable housing projects.